

TOPIC 3: THE CONSTITUTION

1. Meaning of Constitution

A constitution is the supreme law of a country. It sets out how the government is organised, the powers of different arms of government, the rights of citizens, and the rules for making and changing laws. In Nigeria, the current Constitution is the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1999 (as amended).

2. Features of a Constitution

- Supremacy – it is the highest law; other laws must conform to it.
- Separation of powers – among the executive, legislature and judiciary.
- Fundamental rights – protected for citizens and persons.
- Federal structure (in Nigeria) – division of powers between federal, state and local governments.
- Procedures for amendment – so that it can be changed only by clear, deliberate process.

3. Importance in Governance

The constitution limits the power of rulers, protects citizens from abuse, provides stability and predictability, and gives legitimacy to government actions that follow its rules. Without a constitution (or respect for it), government can become arbitrary.

4. Summary

The constitution is the supreme law that organises government, protects rights and guides governance. Respecting it is essential for democracy and the rule of law.

End of Topic 3